
Constructing the Enemy: Network Analysis of Anti-Hussite Vocabulary in Late Medieval Diplomatic Correspondence

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Abstract

Reading the correspondence between Grand Duke Vytautas of Lithuania, King Jogaila of Poland, the Holy Roman Emperor Sigismund of Luxembourg, Pope Martin V, and the Grand Master of the Teutonic Order concerning the Hussites (1421–1430) (sources) reveals a striking absence of discussion about the conceptual nature of heresy itself; the notion of hereticality is treated as self-evident, something typical for ideological texts (Turunen 2024, 3–7). The letters exchanged instead focus extensively on the harm caused by heretics and the urgent need for active measures against them. Since the anti-Hussite struggle shaped diplomatic relations, trade, and military alliances, it must be understood as part of a broader political ideology. This study asks how rhetorical strategies of naming, denouncing, and delegitimising heretics are structured within this correspondence.

For a lexical social-network analysis (proven fruitful in *Heretical Studies*: Zbíral, Brys, and Hinz-Wieczorek 2024), six thematic word pattern clusters were selected: common anti-heretical vocabulary (red); rhetorical insults (green); disease/poison metaphors (purple); comparisons with other excluded groups such as pagans or barbarians (brown); actions to be taken against heretics (blue); and actions attributed to heretics aimed at destabilising social order (orange). The results indicate that the dominant clusters are the naming and classification of heretics, as well as concrete descriptions of punitive actions or heretical attacks on social stability. This network of co-occurrences further demonstrates that anti-heretical discourse is structured around a tightly interconnected core linking naming vocabulary ("heres-", "error-") - only rarely referencing Wycliffites or Taborites - with verbs of punitive action ("extirpa-", "extermin-") and juridical-military terms ("bell-", "iur-"). Metaphors of disease and contagion give way to depictions of concrete material damage: killings, dishonour, burning, and law violations. Future research will focus on the chancery of Grand Duke Vytautas, using network analysis to determine whether Vytautas, in the Hussite conflict, emphasised primarily spiritual concerns or the defence of the broader social order.

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